

Canon EOS 550D

The D5000 has company



Specifications

18 MP sensor, 18-55 mm lens kit, sensor size: 22.3 x 14.9 mm, shutter speed: 1/4000th – 30 sec, sensor sensitivity: 100 – 6400 ISO, 3-inch LCD
Dimensions: 128.8 x 97.5 x 75.3 mm, weight: 475 g (body)

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 Price: Rs 51,995

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Build Quality7.5
 Features8
 Performance7
 Value for money6.5

Enthusiasts, photographers and specifically Canon fans would have been excited and awaiting the release of the EOS 550D or the snazzy Rebel T2i as its better known as in other regions of the world. The upper mid-range DSLRs segment seems to be dominated by the Nikon D90 and the entry-mid range by the recent D5000. The Canon EOS 550D has been around and the 550D was expected and it's finally here.

The 18-megapixel sensor works out to a resolution of 5184 x 3456. The lens kit we received with our 550D was the common 18-55 mm (3x optical zoom equivalent). The Nikon D90 normally comes with a 18-105 mm zoom lens but let's not forget it costs a bit more than the 550D. Liveview looks like a growing trend now. This camera has it too.

The camera body is sturdy

and it feels slightly more bulky and larger than the EOS 1000D, and similarly placed models from Nikon. The right hand grip is very good although the other half of the camera has the very silky smooth plastic feel to it which we aren't particularly fond of.

The placement of buttons and controls are similar to the Nikon DSLRs for the most part. The ISO button is placed somewhat weirdly on top near the jog dial. The jog dial on a fresh 550D is a little more resistant to movement than the Nikon. While the Nikons operate by holding down the control button and rotating the jog dial, the EOS 550D does the same for all the controls except for the ISO. Here, you are expected to click the ISO button and change the setting for it. This just seems a little weird. Two dials dedicated for two controls would have been a nice thing to have.

The camera focuses quickly and uses multiple bursts of flash whenever necessary. Manual focussing is made simple as well in a couple of ways. For one, if you choose a spot focus mode, you can use the focus ring while holding down the shutter release, and the camera will beep to alert you that the object is in focus. Another feature is the zoom feature while focussing. Normally, the button would be used to zoom into captured images. While shooting, you can now zoom in Liveview and get accurate control over the focus. With that little extra time, you can now get flawless images. The large 3-inch LCD screen comes handy.

Video recording is supported and it can do upto 1080p at 30 fps. This takes it a step over the D5000 and even the D90. Canon claims to do 12 minutes of 1080p on a 4GB memory card. A 45 second video took around 240MB at 1080p.

The camera captures detail well but there is visible colour fringing along bright colours. ISO performance is good. There is little noise up to 800 and 1600 range. 3200 and 6400 are available and offer good performance in low light areas. Colours are pretty natural and the camera does try and balance lighting even if you set to manual modes. The lens on the wide range gives a somewhat warped image. If you're buying a camera, we suggest going in for a more capable lens. Macro shots are easy to take and portrait shots come out pretty well under natural light. The flash isn't very powerful.

Canon has also made upgrades to its interface. Things are made simpler; the interface has the cosmetic blur effect while switching between menus. If you're tired of the black and white control screen, you even have the option to switch to other colour presets.

The Canon EOS 550D isn't an upgrade going from say an old EOS 400D or even a 500D. If you're a point and shoot camera user, the 550D makes sense but it's difficult to advice people to go in for it. The good 'ol Nikon D90 is always an option, which is a step up on the EOS 550D and even the D5000. At Rs. 51,995, it doesn't fall into everyone's budget.